This proved right. I returned unannounced the next day and found that the alloy has been removed from the machinery. The previous day was stage managed. I took it as a personal insult and demanded to see the top man. The floor managers kept apologising, but I would settle for nothing less than an explanation from the CEO. I was taken to him.

'What's your problem?' I confronted him. 'Is there a difficulty in fabricating the gas bottles? If so tell me, I will solve the problem for you. Why should you do a drama with us?'

He was apologetic, but I insisted on a solution. He had none.

'I will cancel the order,' I said.

'You can't do that, we are such a big establishment.' The CEO's tone had changed.

That sounded almost like a counter threat. And I was only too happy to prove him wrong.

'Okay, either this contract will be scrapped or I will not remain the project director of the second stage of PSLV.'

I left in a huff and headed straight to the ISRO chairman's office in Bangalore.

'I am cancelling the L&T contract for gas bottles,' I told the chairman. My unspoken message was this, 'The order should stand cancelled no matter what the company represented to the chairman.'

Soon the L&T honchos were shaking their heads in disbelief when the ISRO order cancelling the contract reached their headquarters. The company's representatives now came pleading to me. I politely told them that if I needed their services I would let them know. Later, we got the hemispheres for the gas bottles fabricated by another company.

Back at the ISRO work floor, I continued to be a taskmaster. By now some from the Vernon team that had closely worked together on Vikas-Viking, had been sent back to other units; I got some of them back. And there were a few who I wanted to weed out, either because of lack of urgency or skills. I was soon left with a committed group of scientists, engineers and workers who shared a vision, goal and pride.